

“Meaningful” or “meaningless” social interactions? The automation of commenting in live streams on Douyin

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Addressing the commercialisation of sociality on Douyin

- **Douyin** and its international sister app TikTok are amongst the most used social media globally.
- On Douyin, streamers can pre-write **promotional comments** which users can then post with one tap to enter prize draws.
- The feature is one of many aspects that exemplify Douyin's intensified **commercialisation** of social interaction and entertainment (Su 2023)
- While research has examined the structural dimensions of these shifts, the socio-cultural impacts remain under-examined in the literature.

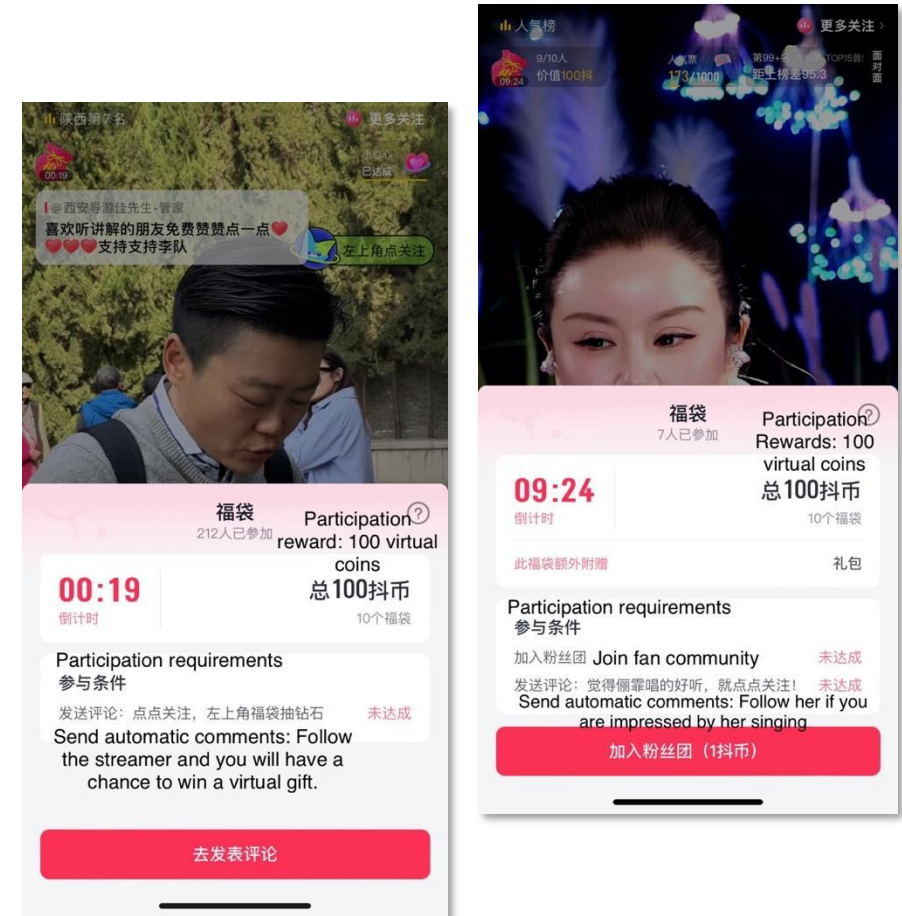


Figure: Screenshots of pre-written automatic live comments on Douyin.



Social media and the complexification of attention economies



User information regimes

Platforms openly share performance metrics that directly influence audience and creator behaviours (Webster, 2010, 2016; Baym, 2010; Burgess and Green, 2018).



Creator culture

The commercialization of online creators fundamentally reshaped digital entertainment and advertising economies (Cunningham and Craig, 2019; Craig et al., 2021; Kaye et al., 2021; Su, 2023).



Liveness

Live streaming has emerged as a key interactive format, driving engagement across both gaming and e-commerce (Scannell, 2014; Taylor, 2018; Su, 2019; Zhou et al., 2019; Lupinacci, 2021; Zhao et al., 2023).



Personalisation

Algorithms now leverage detailed behavioural profiling to optimize personalized engagement and persuasive advertising (Turow, 2012; Webster, 2016; Kant, 2020; Su, 2023).



Looking at what people do rather than the structures alone

- How do users actively construct relationships and **navigate highly commercialized online spaces** for their own social needs?
- What is the **quality of the sociable experiences** audiences derive from participating in live-streaming environments?
- How do users subjectively perceive and **creatively utilize Douyin's live chat** feature to forge genuine connections despite its commercial affordances?

Four-month digital ethnography with diary interviews

Ethnographic observation

~3 hrs/day, 4 months; top-10, ~200 and ~500 ranked streamers across 20+ genres. Screen recordings, screenshots, reflexive memos.

Diary + interview

21 Douyin users (8M/12F, avg 29). 7-day screen-recorded diaries + 50–60 min follow-up interviews; grounded, iterative thematic analysis.

The context of reward-driven clicks

- 18/21 participants actively used **automatic commenting**
- Framed as effortless: "just take one second to press the red button"
- Users know they post **promotional speech**, but reward outweighs reflection



"I always produce automatic comments to participate in the lucky draw to win something ... I don't know why they need us to publish live comments like that and how they gain revenue from this ... I am still willing to participate because it don't ask for much of my effort to consider what to write and type words, rather, just take one second to press the red button and the pre-written comment was published automatically".

Algorithmically programmed engagement with live content

- Users did not seek out commerce streams, Douyin **recommended** them
- Trending events (e.g. Hebei floods) surfaced book-selling streams to sympathetic viewers
- Promotional speech becomes **algorithmically triggered**, not self-initiated



"I have never paid attention to live broadcasts for buying books, but they have been recommended to me a lot when Hebei disaster occurred... I clicked into these recommended live broadcasts to support them."

Encouraging promotional speech

- 13/21 posted promotional comments hoping for a **streamer response**
- Streamers selectively reply to product-related comments, a **pseudo-social** filter (Thurlow 2013)
- "Raw" rural personas performed to mobilise sympathy and sales



"Rural streamers offer performances to take advantage of audiences' sympathy... they just perform to be rural. These promotional strategies gain them many supportive live chats and promotional comments."

Discouraged social interactions in live streams

- 7/21 of participants commented often but **refused** the lucky-bag flow
- Rapid-fire automatic posts **drown out** peer chat and undermining genuine interaction
- Some viewers migrate to **smaller streamers** to preserve real dialogue with audiences



"I enjoy chatting with peer users in live streams, and I sometimes make friends there. However, as an increasing number of live streamers ask users to publish automatic live comments, the live comments pop up very fast, and I can hardly communicate with others. So, I no longer watch streamers with a large number of followers and turn to less popular live streamers who do not adopt automatic commenting frequently"

Users are aware and still play along

- Contrasting some earlier studies which suggest people fail to understand commodification dynamics (Andrejevic, 2015; Caplan & Gillespie, 2020), **users are conscious of the valuation of their participation** and are willing to engage for the rewards they can reap from it.
- Although a majority of participants create promotional speech for rewards and social response from the streamer, some of them did so driven by **a sense of moral obligation** without any exterior reward expected.

✓ **Conclusions: Developing the "commercialised sociality" concept**

- **Enabled by commercialized infrastructures:** Tools like automatic one-click commenting transform social engagement from a self-initiated activity into a constructed sociocultural behaviour shaped by platform design.
- **Facilitated by algorithmic curation:** Recommendation systems actively guide and engineer user interactions, shifting the environment away from simple, organic social collaboration.
- **Stimulated by reward strategies and mutual recognition:** Users are often highly conscious of their commodification, willingly exchanging promotional live chats for social responses or tangible rewards – though some participate driven solely by a sense of moral obligation.
- **Monetized by platforms and streamers:** While corporations and creators successfully commodify real-time engagement for profit, a critical distinction persists between the platform's economic motives and the users' authentic social intentions.

Thank you

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